# Bruce Almighty - Screenplay

## By Steve Koren, Mark O'Keefe and Steve Oedekerk

*Kowolski's Bakery: A news crew shuttles around a gigantic cookie. News reporter BRUCE NOLAN looks into a mirror, desperately trying to place a large segment of wayward hair.*

**BRUCE: (Pg 2-3)** Oh, God, no! The hair's wrong. This is a bad sign.

**ALLY:** Not to worry, you're going to look great in this *(holds out a hair net)*

**BRUCE:** A hair net? I'm not wearing a hair net! You should tell me this beforehand, this is like a huge waste of moose.

**ALLY:** Health code. Around the cookie, you gotta have it.

**BRUCE:** *(Dons the hairnet, looking ridiculous and disgruntled)*

**ALLY:** *(laughing)* A thing of beauty. In 3 . . . 2 . . . 1 . . .

**BRUCE:** *(snaps from disgruntled to charismatic TV newsman)* For three decades the Kowolski Family Bakery has been a mainstay in downtown Buffalo. Today, in honor of their 30-year anniversary, Momma Kowolski and her sons decided to do something a little bit different. Tell me guys, how did this idea come about?

**GUSTOV:** Well, Vol said to me, 'Gustov, why don't we make the biggest chocolate chip cookie in Buffalo?' And I said, 'Yeah, sure.'

**BRUCE:** The previous Buffalo cookie record was 3 feet, 17 inches baked by Gladys Pelsnick. But this behemoth cookie clearly proves that Gustov and Vol have much more free time . . . And that's the way the cookie crumbles. I'm Bruce Nolan, Eyewitness News. *(off camera, he drops his newscaster persona) (sighs)* I'm never going to get anchor doing these kind of assignments. It's a story about a cookie! It sucks! People with eating disorders will be riveted! *(goes into huge pathetic fan character)* Dear Bruce, love the bakery piece. I can't wait to vomit so I can make room for more cookies. *(beat)* I want my work to matter.

## INTRODUCTION

*But when Bruce is not only passed over for the News Anchor position he's been vying for, and is instead fired, his faith is pushed to the breaking point. Even his long-time girlfriend, Grace, can't lift his spirits. Bruce Almighty by Steve Koren, Mark O'Keefe and Steve Oedekerk.*

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**BRUCE:** **(Pg 28-29)** Thanks for everything, Lord. I am so honored that my horrible demise is a part of your loving and mysterious plan.

**GRACE:** Bruce, don't talk like that.

**BRUCE:** Oh, don't worry, he's not listening. If he is he doesn't care. Have you seen the news lately? We got gangs, we got drugs, we got corruption. What kind of God lets that happen? Every time we cure a disease he comes up with a new one! *(as God)* Yeah, is this the lab? Yeah, it's God. They've just come up with a treatment for syphilis down there. I think it's time to release the tainted monkey. Oh, and there's a guy in Ohio who's praying for strength and wisdom, blind him and cut off his legs. Think about it, Grace. God is all powerful. He could fix everything in five minutes if he wanted to. But he doesn't want to. He doesn't like me.

**GRACE:** Bruce, please. This isn't his fault.

**BRUCE:** Of course not. *(hushed tone)* It's part of the mysterious plan. *(growing in volume; he looks heavenward, challenging the Infinite)* News flash: I'm not okay with a mediocre job. I'm not okay with a mediocre LIFE! The gloves are off, pal! Let me see a little wrath! Smite me, oh mighty smiter! What, no pestilence, boils? Come on, you got me on the ropes, don't you want to finish me off?! You're the one who should be fired! The only one around here not doing his job is YOU! *(Phone rings, Bruce answers)*

**PHONE VOICE:** **(Pg 33)** Denied that promotion at work? Is life unfair? Everywhere you turn is there someone less talented than you reaping all the benefits? Is your name Bruce? Then do we have the job for you. We're located at 77256 23rd Street . . . So come on down, or we'll just keep beepin' ya.

******* 77256 23rd Street*******

*Bruce enters and checks the building directory*

**GOD as JANITOR:** **(Pg 33-39)** *(mopping the floor)* You're looking for Room 7. That'd be on the seventh floor. Stairs are right over there.

**BRUCE:** *(takes the stairs; at the top he sees a man on a ladder)* Excuse me. Hello. I'm, ah, looking for whoever runs this joint. . .

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**GOD as ELECTRICIAN:** Be right with ya, just fixin' a light. Tell me if it's working? *(click -- an insanely bright white light shines down, blinding Bruce)*

**BRUCE:** Yep, seems to be. *(wiping his eyes)* Kinda bright, though.

**GOD as ELECTRICIAN:** Yeah, it is for most people. They spend their lives in the dark. . . thinkin' they can hide from me. The boss'll be right out. *(Janitor unzips his uniform, revealing a very nice suit. He extends his hand to Bruce)* You must be Bruce. I've been expecting you. *(He steps behind a desk)*

**BRUCE:** Oh, this is hilarious. So, you're the boss and the electrician and the janitor. How did you get my number?

**GOD:** Oh, I know a lot about you Bruce. Everything you've ever said, done or thought about doin' *(picks up a file)* Now this last entry was a little disturbing. *(scanning)* "Thanks for everything, Lord. The gloves are off, pal . . . Smite me, oh mighty smiter. *(aside)* I'm not much for blaspheming but that one made me laugh.

**BRUCE:** *(dazed)* Who are you?

**GOD:** I'm the creator of the heavens and the earth. I'm the Alpha & Omega.

**BRUCE:** Sorry, it's not ringing a bell.

**GOD:** I'm God, Bruce.

**BRUCE:** Oh, you're God. Well, that explains everything! That's how you got up to the seventh floor so quickly. *(placating)* Well, it's really nice to meet you. Thanks for the Grand Canyon and, ah, good luck with the apocalypse. *(turns to leave, but finds himself walking right toward God and his desk. He tries again, and again)* Okay. That's good. That's a good one.

**GOD:** You've been doing a lot of complaining about me, Bruce. And quite frankly, I'm tired of it... I brought you here to offer you a job. My job. You think you can do it better, so here's your chance. When you leave this building, you will be endowed with all my powers. All the power of God.

**BRUCE:** Sure, whatever you say, Pal. *(a beat, then Bruce sprints out of the room)*

******* A Diner, Later the Same Day *******

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**BRUCE: (Pg 40-45)** *(talking to himself)* I'm having a breakdown. That's what it is. Just a normal, everyday psychotic episode, brought on by tumor or brain lesion . . . *(laughs)* Okay, just relax here. I did not meet God and I do not have his powers. *(to waitress, embarrassed)* Oh, hi, ah, coffee please.

*(She pours him a cup and heads off. Bruce looks at the sugar at the end of the table, holds out his hand and the sugar slides across the table right into it. The creamer slides into his other hand. He is half scared; half thrilled. He pours cream and sugar into his cup, then looks around the table)*

**BRUCE:** Excuse me I need a spoooo. . . *(a spoon appears in his hand, he wipes it off with his napkin)* That's alright, I found one.

*GOD: (suddenly appears beside the booth) Havin' fun? (Bruce is now awestruck) Okay, let me* explain the rules. you left in such a rush I didn't get a chance to explain.

**BRUCE:** Well [it] freaked me out a little bit.

**GOD:** I did the same thing to Ghandi, he couldn't eat for three weeks. Now, here's the deal. There are only two rules. You can't tell anyone you're God. Believe me you don't want that kind of attention. And you can't mess with free will.

**BRUCE:** Uh huh. Can I - ask why?

**GOD:** *(excited)* Yes you can. That's the beauty it. I'll be seein' ya. *(God begins to walk away)* I'm taking a vacation.

**BRUCE:** God can't take a vacation. Can he? Can you?

**GOD:** Ever hear of the Dark Ages? Besides, I'm covered. You can fix everything in five minutes if you want to, right?

**BRUCE: (Pg 50)** *(strikes a God-like pose and proclaims)* I AM THE LORD, THY BRUCE ALMIGHTY. MY WILL BE DONE! *(a new, confident Bruce)* [Now] **(Pg 56)** to get my job back!

*******Scene*******

**ON a TV, DAN RATHER: (Pg 58-59)** The body of Jimmy Hoffa was uncovered in a field today outside of a canine training center in Buffalo New York. Local Buffalo freelance field reporter Bruce Nolan was the first on the scene . . .

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**BRUCE:** . . . As you can see behind us, the body is being carefully exhumed and will be transported to a hospital facility where DNA testing will confirm the identity. That, of course, only a formality as in a bizarre twist, the body was found buried with a birth certificate and complete set of dental records . . . **(Pg 3)** And that's the way the cookie crumbles.

**JACK (Bruce's Former Boss):** **(Pg 62-63)** Look, I'll be straight. We want you back, Bruce. Look, it's not in my power to give you anchor, but as far as field reporting goes . . .

**BRUCE:** Jack, don't worry about that. Just give me a camera and a crew and I'll give you the news. *(Bruce interviewing an old lady at the Mark Twain chili cook off)*

**OLD LADY:** **(Pg 66)** My secret is I let the jalapeno's marinade in a spicy sauce . . .

**BRUCE:** *(gets an idea, then suddenly)* . . . Hold that thought, Hazel! It seems some type of meteor or asteroid has, by chance, hit the earth right behind the Mark Twain Chili Cook Off. . . **(Pg 3)** And that's the way the cookie crumbles. *(cut to Bruce free-falling in a sky diving uniform)* **(Pg 66-67)** . . . So remember, it's sky diving season at Old Pete's airfield *(grabs the ripcord)* This is Bruce Nolan. . . *(gives it a tug)* My rip cord appears to be stuck. This is very unfortunate. I'm heading toward the earth at a very precarious speed . . . *(he falls into a wooded area)*

**BYSTANDERS:** *(running to his aid)* He's okay! What's that? It's Bigfoot! Bigfoot broke his fall!

**BRUCE:** *(stands groggy, points to a dazed Bigfoot)* Ah ha! You are real!. . . **(Pg 69)** And that's the way the cookie crumbles. *(standing casually with his arm around Bigfoot)* **(Pg 3)** I'm Bruce Nolan, Eyewitness News.

*****Scene*****

*(Bruce reacts to voices he hears in his head, voices only he can hear. He shakes his head, covers his ears, looks around for where the sounds may be coming from, he is perplexed)*

**OFF STAGE VOICE:** **(Pg 75-76)** *(louder)* Please! Help me! Please!

**GOD:** Really something isn't it?

**BRUCE:** Those voices . . .

**GOD:** They're prayers, Bruce. You keep ignoring them and they're going to build up on. you like that. You didn't think being God was going to be all fun and games did you? You've had

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my powers for over a week now and how many people have you helped? *(the whispers start again, and Bruce reacts)*

**BRUCE: (Pg 78-79)** *(hands over his ears)* Not now!

**GOD:** You wanted the job, Bruce. I suggest you get to it.

*******Next Day, Bruce's Apartment*******

**BRUCE: (Pg 79-80)** Okay, first off, this creepy whisper thing has got to go. *(paces)* Organization and management. I need a system. Something concrete . . . *(an idea – Bruce waves his hand and now stands before a high-tech computer, he taps some keys)* Welcome to the information super highway. No mess, full bless!

**COMPUTER VOICE:** Downloading Prayers . . . 1,567,432 unread messages.

**BRUCE: (Pg 85)** *(cracks his knuckles and begins answering prayers, his fingers move faster and faster)* He reads out loud the prayers and responses) I've got to find a better job . . . Promotion with a 15% raise. Come on light, turn . . . It's green. God, I wish I were thinner . . Donuts are now healthy.

**COMPUTER VOICE:** *(Ding)* 3 million unread messages.

**BRUCE:** Oh, come on. What a bunch of whiners. This is going to suck up my whole life. *(he gets an idea, taps a few keys)* Answer all . . . Yes. And Enter *(he hits the Enter key with a flourish)*

******Scene******

**GRACE: (Pg 87)** Oh, you'll never believe it. Debbie won the lottery. But get this, there were like 433 thousand other winners, so it only paid out 17 dollars. Can you believe the odds of that?

**BUSINESSMAN (Pg 91)** My tech stocks tripled in five days!

**HEAVY WOMAN:** I lost 47 lbs on the Krispy Kreme diet.

*******Scene*******

**NEWSCASTER #1: (Pg 101)** The Dow skyrocketed again today and with a new influx of paper millionaires, analysts are warning of a potential run on banks. . .

**NEWSANCHOR #2:** The scene nearly turned violent when hundreds of disgruntled Buffalo residents protested the results of last week's fluke lottery results. . .

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******* 77256 23rd Street*******

*(Bruce stands there, sees God as he originally found him, mopping.)*

**BRUCE: (Pg 106-107)** They're all out of control. I don't know what to do.

**GOD:** *(not surprised to see Bruce)* You mind giving me a hand with this floor first? *(Bruce rolls up his sleeves and grabs a mop; God sings)* **"Poor man wanna be rich, Rich man wanna be king, And a king ain't satisfied, 'Til he rules everything . . . "** *(to Bruce)* Springsteen. I like a little Boss in my head while I'm workin' . . . *(they finish and survey the sparkling floor)* There we go. Wonderful thing. No matter how filthy something gets, it can always be cleaned right up.

**BRUCE:** What happened? I gave everyone what they wanted.

**GOD:** Since when does anyone have a clue about what they want? Have you seen the news lately? *(takes a remote from his pocket and clicks, a projection appears)*

**NEWSCASTER: (Pg 108-109)** Scientists believe last week's asteroid may have knocked the earth off its axis resulting in the rapid acceleration of the melting of the polar caps. . .

**GOD:** *(to Bruce, again using Bruce's words)* Now what kind of a God let's that happen? Not as easy as it looks, is it? This God business. Everybody wants a miracle, Bruce. Want me to do everything for 'em. But what they don't understand is, they're the one's holding the power. That's everybody's problem. You keep looking up . . .

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Steve Koren, Mark O'Keefe and Steve Oedekerk***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2019 National Qualifier***
***2020 National Qualifier***
***2021 National Qualifier***
***NIETOC***
***MN State Qualifier***

****music and lyrics for Bruce Springsteen's Badlands (starts at 1:35)***
*https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o5IZuuzUa04*

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